A SERMON FOR THE PULPIT

The One-Verse Deliverer

A sermon on Shamgar

THE BIG IDEA

The size of your mention is not the size of your work: God saved Israel through a farmer with an oxgoad, and Jesus is the greater Deliverer whose name is above every name.

PRIMARY TEXT	Judges 3:31
ALSO READ	Judges 5:6–8; 1 Samuel 13:19–22; Hebrews 11:32; Philippians 2:5–11
TIME	55–60 minutes, including a 3–5 minute response.

Scripture quotations are ESV. Swap to your pulpit translation freely.

A COMPLETE MANUSCRIPT FOR THE PULPIT

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Introduction: The shortest story

There are people in the Bible who get chapters. Abraham gets fourteen. David gets a whole dynasty. Paul gets letters. Then there is Shamgar.

Shamgar gets a sentence.

Not a paragraph. Not a scene. A sentence. It is tucked into the book of Judges like a note in the margin, one line between the end of Ehud's story and the beginning of Deborah's. If you read too fast, you will miss him. Most of us have.

Here is the sentence: "After him was Shamgar the son of Anath, who killed 600 of the Philistines with an oxgoad, and he also saved Israel" (Judges 3:31).

That is all. No birth. No calling. No sermon. No last words. No death. No tomb. A name, a father, an enemy, a number, a tool, and a verdict. Six things. That is the whole file.

And yet the verdict is the same verdict the book gives its greatest heroes. "He also saved Israel." The Hebrew verb is the same one used of Othniel, Ehud, Deborah, Gideon, Jephthah, and Samson. The book does not grade on length. It does not hand out a shorter salvation because the story is short. It says he saved Israel, and it moves on.

We live in a world that measures by mention. Followers. Views. By-lines. Job titles. The size of the obituary. We have taught ourselves to believe that if a life is not documented, it did not matter; that if no one saw it, it did not count; that if the record is short, the work must be small. Shamgar is in the Bible to break that lie.

The size of your mention is not the size of your work.

That is the big idea of this sermon. And it is not a soft sentiment for people who feel overlooked. It is a theological claim about the God who writes His own record. God is not a publisher counting column inches. He is the LORD who raises up deliverers, sends them into fields and courtrooms and kitchens and classrooms, and measures their lives by a different ledger.

Here is where we are going. We will look at the world Shamgar lived in, because Deborah's song tells us what it was like. We will look at the man himself, including the strange name he carried. We will look at the tool in his hand, because the tool is the point. We will look at the number, because six hundred is not a throwaway detail. And then we will look past Shamgar to the greater Deliverer, the One whose name is not a footnote but the name above every name.

One verse. One man. One tool. One salvation. And one Savior.

Let us read it again, slowly: "After him was Shamgar the son of Anath, who killed 600 of the Philistines with an oxgoad, and he also saved Israel."

Movement 1: The roads went quiet

Before we meet Shamgar, we need to understand the world he woke up in. And for that, we have a window most readers miss. It is a song.

Judges 5 is the Song of Deborah, one of the oldest extended poems in the Hebrew Bible. It celebrates the defeat of Sisera, and it opens with a memory of the years before the victory. Listen to how it describes the world:

"In the days of Shamgar, son of Anath, in the days of Jael, the highways were abandoned, and travelers kept to the byways. The villagers ceased in Israel; they ceased to be until I arose; I, Deborah, arose as a mother in Israel. When new gods were chosen, then war was in the gates. Was shield or spear to be seen among forty thousand in Israel?" (Judges 5:6–8).

Read that again. The highways were abandoned. Travelers kept to the byways. The villagers ceased. Not slowed down. Ceased. The main roads belonged to someone else, so people took the goat tracks and the long way around. Markets went quiet. Farmsteads pulled in on themselves. The open road became a rumor.

That is what occupation feels like from the inside. It is not only an army in the valley. It is the road you no longer take. It is the trip you no longer make. It is the friend you no longer visit because the highway is not safe after dark. It is a whole society shrinking to the size of what it can defend.

And then the song asks the question that explains everything: "Was shield or spear to be seen among forty thousand in Israel?" Forty thousand people, and the weapons census comes to zero. This is not a nation preparing for war. This is a nation that has been disarmed and told to be quiet about it.

The Philistines were the reason. They were not a wandering raiding party. They were a settled, organized, technologically superior power on the coastal plain. They worked iron. They had chariots. They had garrison towns. Theirs was the age's military revolution, and Israel was still a hill-country people with slings and staffs. When the Philistines said, "No blacksmiths for you,"

they were not being cruel for cruelty's sake. They were doing what empires do: they controlled the means of making weapons.

We get the picture in 1 Samuel 13. "Now there was no blacksmith to be found throughout all the land of Israel, for the Philistines said, 'Lest the Hebrews make themselves swords or spears.' But every one of the Israelites went down to the Philistines to sharpen his plowshare, his mattock, his axe, or his sickle" (1 Samuel 13:19–20). Can you see it? An Israelite farmer walking down the hill to an enemy forge to pay an enemy smith to sharpen the blade he uses to feed his family. The occupation reached all the way into his toolshed.

That is the world of Judges 3:31. A people with no swords, no spears, no smiths, and no safe roads. A people whose villages had ceased. A people who had traded the worship of the living God for the gods of the land and were now living under the boot of the neighbors those gods belonged to.

But here is the thing about the book of Judges: it never lets the oppression have the last word. "Then the LORD raised up judges, who saved them out of the hand of those who plundered them" (Judges 2:16). The pattern is stubborn. Sin. Oppression. Cry. Deliverance. Relapse. And over and over, when the situation is hopeless, God raises someone up.

Sometimes He raises up an army. Sometimes He raises up a prophet. Sometimes He raises up a left-handed assassin named Ehud, who carries a dagger to a king's throne room. And sometimes, in the case of Shamgar, He raises up a farmer with a stick.

The roads went quiet. But God had not gone quiet. The villages ceased. But God had not ceased. And into a world with no shield and no spear, God sent a man with an oxgoad.

Movement 2: The man from the edge

His name is Shamgar. We do not know what it means. We do not know where he was born. We do not know how old he was, whether he was married, whether he had children, whether he was rich or poor. We know his father's name, Anath, and we know the era he lived in, and that is almost the whole biography.

The father's name is a puzzle. Anath was a Canaanite goddess, a warrior goddess associated with violence and war. A man named "Shamgar son of Anath" sounds, to Israelite ears, like a man from the wrong side of the tracks. Some scholars think the name points to Beth-Anath, a village in the territory of Naphtali listed in Joshua 19:38. Some think "son of Anath" was a family

name or a clan designation. Some point to Egyptian records from the age of Ramesses the Great that preserve the phrase "Ben-Anath" as a warrior name or title. The text does not tell us which explanation is right, and we should not pretend that it does.

But the ambiguity is not a problem for the story. It is part of the story's point.

The book of Judges has a pattern, and the pattern is that God keeps choosing the wrong people. Ehud is left-handed, which in that culture is a disadvantage or a stigma, and he uses it to surprising effect. Deborah is a woman in a world that did not expect women to lead, and she becomes the mother of Israel. Gideon is the least of his father's house. Jephthah is the son of a prostitute. Samson is a walking disaster with a Nazirite vow. The book is a gallery of people nobody would have picked.

Shamgar fits that gallery. A man whose name carries the enemy's goddess is not a scandal to the pattern. He is the pattern. God does not wait for a clean résumé before He hands someone a harvest. He does not require a pedigree before He gives a deliverance. He takes the people at the edge of the map and puts them at the center of the story.

There is something else here, and it is easy to miss. The verse says, "After him was Shamgar." After him. After Ehud. The previous deliverer was the assassin with the hidden dagger, the man who killed a Moabite king in a locked room and then walked away. Shamgar comes after a very different kind of hero. He does not try to be Ehud. He does not stage a palace coup. He goes back to the field, picks up the tool he uses every day, and does what he can do.

That is a word for anyone who has ever felt like they missed their moment. You do not have to be the last deliverer. You do not have to replicate someone else's calling. You have your own field, your own tool, your own generation. Faithfulness is not a competition with the person who came before you.

And notice what the text does not give him. It does not give him a call scene. It does not say the Spirit of the LORD came upon him, as it says of Othniel, Gideon, Jephthah, and Samson. It does not give him a speech, a dialogue, a prayer, or a complaint. It does not even say he was an Israelite, though the context implies it. The silence is so complete that some readers have wondered whether the verse is a fragment.

But the silence is doing something. It is telling us that the deed was the point, not the biography. Shamgar did not leave a memoir. He left a field with fewer enemies in it. The text remembers what he did, not what he said, and it remembers the people he saved, not the platform he built.

We are tempted to reverse that. We want the platform. We want the memoir. We want the scene where everyone sees us being brave. Shamgar gets one sentence, and the sentence is enough, because the sentence ends with "he also saved Israel."

There is one more detail worth holding. The verse says "After him." It does not say "In his place." Shamgar is not a replacement for Ehud; he is a continuation of God's work. The deliverance of God is not a single event with a single hero. It is a long chain of ordinary people doing what God gives them to do in the generation they are given. Some links are famous. Some links are one verse long. The chain holds either way.

Movement 3: The tool in his hand

Now we come to the detail the whole verse turns on: the oxgoad.

The Hebrew phrase is *malmad habbaqar*, the goad of the cattle. It is not a sword. It is not a spear. It is not a sling or a bow. It is a farm tool, and it is worth understanding exactly what it was.

An oxgoad was a long pole, often as tall as a man or taller, made of seasoned hardwood. At one end was a sharp iron point. At the other was a flat iron blade, like a chisel. The point was used to prod the ox forward when it stalled. The flat blade was used to scrape the heavy clay off the plow point when it clogged. A farmer carried it every day. He used it to drive, guide, and correct the animals that pulled his plow. It was in his hand more than any other tool he owned.

In trained hands, an eight-foot pole with iron at both ends is not a stick. It is a pike with a work history. The man holding it had spent years learning reach, angle, and timing. He knew how to move a ton of animal without breaking stride. He knew how to plant the point and turn a charging ox. He had a farmer's reflexes and a farmer's patience. When he picked up that goad to face a Philistine, he was not picking up a random piece of wood. He was picking up the tool he knew better than his own hands.

But why a goad? Why not a sword?

Because he did not have a sword. That is the plain answer, and it is the theological answer. The Philistines had disarmed Israel. There were no smiths in the land. The blacksmiths were on the coastal plain, and they were not taking orders from Hebrews. So when the moment came, Shamgar had what a farmer has: a goad. He did not wait for better equipment. He did not say, "If only I had a sword." He used what was in his hand.

This is one of the great patterns of Scripture. God does not wait for the right tools. He uses the tools that are already in the hands of the people He calls. Moses had a staff, and God used it to part the sea. David had a sling and five smooth stones, and God used them to bring down a giant. A widow had a jar of oil, and God used it to pay a debt. A boy had five loaves and two fish, and Jesus used them to feed a crowd. A woman had a jar of perfume, and she broke it over the feet of the Son of God. A group of disciples had a towel and a basin, and Jesus used them to teach the church how to love.

The goad is in that family. It is the ordinary tool in the ordinary hand, offered to an extraordinary God.

There is a detail in the Hebrew that makes this even richer. The word for goad comes from a root that means to teach or train. A goad is not only a driving instrument; it is an instrument of instruction. It teaches the ox which way to go. It corrects the animal that resists. In Acts 26:14, the risen Jesus says to Saul of Tarsus, "It is hard for you to kick against the goads." The picture is of an animal fighting the very instrument that is trying to guide it.

Shamgar's weapon was an instrument of training. That is a picture of how God often works. He uses the hard things in our lives to move us in the right direction. He uses the pressure of a difficult job, the weight of a responsibility, the disappointment of a closed door, the goad of a consequence, to teach us to walk in His ways. That is not to say that every suffering is a divine goad, or that every painful circumstance is a message about our sin. The Bible is too honest for that. But it is to say that God is not wasting the hard things. He is a farmer who knows how to guide the animal He owns.

And the goad is a picture of the Word of God. Hebrews 4:12 says, "For the word of God is living and active, sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing to the division of soul and of spirit, of joints and of marrow, and discerning the thoughts and intentions of the heart." The Word is sharp. It probes. It corrects. It does not leave us where it finds us. The same God who used a farmer's goad to save a nation uses the sharp word of the gospel to save a soul.

But notice: the goad did not save Israel by itself. A tool is only as good as the hand that holds it, and even the best hand is not the power. The text says Shamgar killed six hundred with the goad, but the book of Judges says the LORD is the one who saves. The tool is not the hero. The hand is not the hero. God is the hero, and He is pleased to use farm tools and farmers to do His work.

So here is the question the goad asks you: What is in your hand?

Not what is in someone else's hand. Not what you wish were in your hand. Not what you would have if you had a different job, a different bank account, a different platform, a different life. What is actually in your hand right now? A skill. A relationship. A home. A story. A season of suffering you did not choose. A piece of work that nobody applauds. A single verse.

God has a history of using exactly that.

Movement 4: Six hundred and one

The verse gives us a number: six hundred.

"Who killed 600 of the Philistines with an oxgoad."

Six hundred is not a skirmish. It is a column. It is the size of a raiding force that could hold a road, garrison a town, or terrify a valley. It is the kind of number that makes a farmer's neighbors stop talking when he walks by.

We need to be careful here. The text does not tell us how the six hundred fell. It does not say it happened in one afternoon, in one field, in one charge. It does not give us a battle narrative. It gives us a summary, and the summary is doing theology, not journalism. The number is a way of saying: the deliverance was real, it was costly, and it was disproportionate. One man with a farm tool against a trained column is not a fair fight. That is the point.

Some readers have tried to turn the number into a problem. "No man kills six hundred armed men with a farm tool." Fair enough, if you picture a single duel in a single field. But that is not the only way to picture it. A raiding column has to camp. It has to ford rivers. It has to spread out to forage. It has to sleep. A man who knows the ground, who has spent his life in those fields and wadis, who can move at night and strike at a ford and disappear before the column can form up, can do enormous damage over a season of resistance. Six hundred may be the total of a campaign, not the body count of a minute. The text does not say, and we should not pretend to know.

What the text does say is that the Philistines stopped coming. The highways were abandoned in the days of Shamgar, and the villagers ceased, but then there is a deliverance, and then there is Deborah, and then there is a song. The goad did not end the Philistine threat forever. It did not usher in the millennium. But it broke the back of one column, in one generation, and it bought a people time to breathe. That is what deliverance usually looks like in the book of Judges. It is local, partial, and provisional. It is a foretaste, not the final feast.

The archaeology behind the story is real. The Philistines were a historical people, part of the Sea Peoples whom Ramesses III defeated in the great land and sea battle carved on the walls of his mortuary temple at Medinet Habu, around 1177 BC. Among the prisoners in those reliefs are the Peleset, the Philistines of the Bible. They settled on the coastal plain, in cities like Ashdod, Ashkelon, and Gaza. Excavations in Philistine levels have found iron-working installations and iron tools, which fits the picture of a coastal power with a technological edge over the hill country. The goad itself appears in Egyptian tomb paintings: plowmen driving oxen with long, iron-tipped poles, chisel at one end and point at the other. The tool in Judges 3:31 is not a fanciful detail. It is the kind of tool a real farmer in the real world of the text would have carried every day.

But the evidence does not prove that one man killed six hundred. It supports the setting. It shows us that the world of the verse is the world we know from the ground. The theological claim is not built on the archaeology; it is built on the text. And the text makes a claim that is much bigger than a body count: "He also saved Israel."

That little word "also" is doing a lot of work. It links Shamgar to the other judges. It says: this one counts too. He belongs in the line. He is not a footnote to Ehud or a preface to Deborah. He is a deliverer in his own right, with his own field, his own enemy, and his own salvation.

And the verb "saved" is the same verb the book uses for every judge. It is the verb *yasha*, the root behind the name Joshua, and behind the name Jesus. That is not a coincidence. The Bible's vocabulary of salvation is not an afterthought. It is the thread that runs from the exodus to the judges to the prophets to the manger to the cross. Shamgar saved Israel with a goad. The greater Joshua, the greater Yeshua, would save the world with a cross.

But before we get to the cross, we need to feel the strangeness of this verse. It does not mention God. Read it again: "After him was Shamgar the son of Anath, who killed 600 of the Philistines with an oxgoad, and he also saved Israel." No "the LORD was with him." No "the Spirit of the LORD came upon him." No "the LORD gave them into his hand." Just a man, a tool, a number, and a verdict.

Why would the narrator leave God out? Perhaps because the whole book has already told us who raises up judges. The reader knows the pattern. The reader knows that a deliverer does not appear by accident. The reader knows that the courage to stand in a field with a goad comes from somewhere deeper than the field. The narrator does not need to say it again. The silence is not atheism. It is confidence. The God of Israel is so obviously the one who saves that the story can simply say, "He also saved Israel," and the reader fills in the name.

That is a good model for us. Some of the most faithful work in the world is done by people who never say "look what God is doing" while they do it. They just do the work. They show up in the field. They use the tool. They stand in the gap. And later, when the story is told, it becomes obvious who was behind it.

Six hundred and one. A column and a farmer. A number and a name. And a verdict that will not be silenced by the shortness of the sentence: he also saved Israel.

Movement 5: The Name above every name

Now we turn the corner. Every sermon in this series has to make the turn, because every story in the Old Testament is a signpost, not the destination. Shamgar is not the end of the story. He is a finger pointing forward.

The first thing to notice is the name. The verb "saved" in Judges 3:31 is *yasha*. The name Joshua is *Yehoshua*, "the LORD saves." The Greek form of Joshua is *Iēsous*, Jesus. When the angel spoke to Joseph, he said, "You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins" (Matthew 1:21). The name of the Savior is the verb of Shamgar's victory. The one-verse deliverer is a living echo of the One who is the Word.

But the contrast is even greater than the echo. Shamgar saved Israel by killing six hundred Philistines. Jesus saved the world by letting Himself be killed.

Think about that. The pattern of the judges is that the deliverer takes up a weapon and strikes down the enemy. The pattern of Jesus is that the Deliverer lays down His life and lets the enemy strike Him down. When Peter drew a sword in the garden, Jesus said, "Put your sword back into its place. For all who take the sword will perish by the sword" (Matthew 26:52). When the mob came to arrest Him, He did not call down twelve legions of angels. He did not pick up a goad. He let them bind Him. He let them try Him. He let them nail Him to a cross.

Why? Because the enemy He came to defeat was not Rome. It was not the Philistines. It was not the principalities and powers of the air, not ultimately. It was sin. It was death. It was the record of debt that stood against us. And those enemies cannot be defeated by a sword. They can only be defeated by a substitution. Someone has to die in our place. Someone has to take the nails.

And that is exactly what He did. "He was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed" (Isaiah 53:5). The greater Deliverer was pierced. The soldiers did not use a goad; they

used a spear. "One of the soldiers pierced his side with a spear, and at once there came out blood and water" (John 19:34). The wood of the cross and the iron of the nails became the tools of the greatest deliverance in history.

On the day He died, the mockers said the truest thing anyone said at the cross, though they did not know it: "He saved others; he cannot save himself" (Matthew 27:42). They meant it as a taunt. It was a confession. He could not save Himself and save us. He chose us. He stayed on the cross. He drank the cup. He finished the work.

And then, on the third day, the Father raised Him from the dead. The deliverance was not a temporary break in the cycle. It was the end of the cycle. The grave could not hold Him. Death could not keep Him. And because He lives, everyone who trusts Him lives too.

Philippians 2 tells us what happened next: "Therefore God has highly exalted him and bestowed on him the name that is above every name, so that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father" (Philippians 2:9–11).

Shamgar got one verse. Jesus got the name above every name. Shamgar is remembered in a line. Jesus is worshiped in every tongue. And yet the two are connected, because the God who saved Israel through a farmer with a goad is the God who saved the world through a Son with a cross. The size of the mention is not the size of the work. The one-verse deliverer points to the One who is the Word made flesh.

Now, what about Hebrews 11? You may have noticed that Shamgar is not in the roll call of the faithful. Hebrews 11:32 names Gideon, Barak, Samson, Jephthah, David, Samuel, and the prophets. It does not name Shamgar. It does not name Deborah or Jael either, though their stories are in the same book. The list is selective. It is a sermon, not a census. The absence of a name from a later list does not erase the name from the record. The canon counts verses. Heaven counts deliverance.

But there is a deeper point. Hebrews 11 is not ultimately about the people it names. It is about the One they were waiting for. The whole chapter is a hallway of portraits leading to a door, and the door is Jesus. "And all these, though commended through their faith, did not receive what was promised, since God had provided something better for us, that apart from us they should not be made perfect" (Hebrews 11:39–40). Shamgar's one verse is part of that hallway. It is a portrait of faith in the middle of a dark age. And it points to the One who is the object of all faith.

So here is the gospel invitation of this text. You do not have to be famous to be faithful. You do not have to be in Hebrews 11 to be in heaven's book. You do not have to have a chapter to have a Savior. The God who remembered Shamgar's name when the Bible gave him a sentence has written your name in a book that cannot be lost. And the Savior who is the name above every name is not ashamed to call you His own.

Application: What do you do with one verse?

This is where the text lands on us. Shamgar's one verse asks us four questions.

1. Will you work the field you were given?

Shamgar was a farmer. That is the plain implication of the goad. He was not a king, a priest, or a prophet. He did not have a throne or an altar. He had a field. And the field was where the deliverance started.

Most of us are not called to a throne. We are called to a field. A desk. A classroom. A ward. A shop. A kitchen. A neighborhood. A family. The place where the work is ordinary and the hours are long and nobody is watching. That is where God does His best work. That is where Shamgar picked up the goad.

Do not despise the field. Do not spend your life waiting for a platform that may never come. The field is the platform. The ordinary work is the ministry. The person in front of you is the assignment.

2. Will you use the tool in your hand?

Shamgar did not wait for a sword. He used the tool he had. That is not an excuse for sloppy work or inadequate preparation. It is a call to stop waiting for ideal conditions and start stewarding the actual ones.

What is in your hand? A skill that could serve someone this week. A home that could host a Bible study. A story that could encourage a friend who is losing hope. A season of suffering that has taught you something about God that you could pass on. A sentence of Scripture that has been keeping you alive. A goad.

God does not need you to have what you do not have. He needs you to offer what you do have. The question is not "Do I have enough?" The question is "Will I give what I have?" The boy with five loaves did not have enough to feed the crowd. He gave what he had, and Jesus did the rest.

3. Will you refuse the comparison of mentions?

This is the hardest one for those of us who live online. We can see everyone else's numbers. We can see the platform, the followers, the book deal, the speaking invite, the viral post. And we can start to believe that our one verse is not worth writing.

Shamgar's verse is one line. It is shorter than the genealogy of a king. It is shorter than the description of a garment. It is shorter than the instructions for a sacrifice. And it is in the Bible. It is in the canon. It is read in churches around the world. The size of the mention is not the size of the work.

Comparison is a poor theologian. It measures the wrong thing. It counts the wrong currency. It asks, "Who is more important?" when the better question is, "Who was faithful?" The answer to that question is not always visible in this life. But it is visible to God. And His ledger is the one that lasts.

4. Will you trust the God who counts what the record skips?

Shamgar is not in Hebrews 11. He is not in the Hall of Fame. But he is in the book of Judges, and he is in the hands of God. The record is selective. The salvation is real. Heaven's memory is not limited to the names we put on plaques.

That is a comfort for the unseen. The mother who prays in the dark. The teacher who stays late. The volunteer who sets up chairs. The man who keeps his promise when no one is checking. The woman who forgives when no one would blame her for leaving. The friend who shows up. The worker who does the job right. The one who is faithful in the field with the tool in hand. God sees. God remembers. God rewards.

And the reward is not a bigger mention. It is the Master's "Well done." It is the joy of hearing Him say, "You were faithful over a few things; I will set you over many." It is the privilege of being used by the God of the universe in the one generation you were given.

So do not measure your life by the size of your obituary. Measure it by the size of your faithfulness. The one verse is enough. The one field is enough. The one goad is enough, because the God who holds it is enough.

The invitation

There are three people in this room, and one of them is you.

The first is the person who feels invisible. You have been faithful for years, and no one has noticed. You have served in the nursery, balanced the books, visited the hospital, prayed in the dark, and held the family together. You have one verse, if that. Shamgar is your brother. He knows what it is to be a line in someone else's story. And he knows what it is to hear the verdict of God: "He also saved Israel." The God who saw him sees you.

The second is the person who has been waiting for a weapon. You have been telling yourself that you cannot do anything for God until you have more training, more money, more platform, more courage, more certainty. You have been waiting for the sword. Shamgar picked up the goad. The tool in your hand is not nothing. The field in front of you is not nowhere. The God who used a farmer can use you.

The third is the person who has been fighting the wrong war. You have been treating the people around you as the enemy. You have been swinging a goad at flesh and blood. And you are tired, and you are losing, and you are not even sure why you are fighting anymore. Jesus said, "Put your sword back into its place." The real enemy is sin, and death, and the lies that hold you captive. And the One who defeated those enemies is not asking you to pick up a weapon. He is asking you to come to the cross.

Come to the Deliverer. Not the one with the goad, but the One with the nails in His hands. Not the one who killed the enemy, but the One who died for His enemies. Not the one who got one verse, but the One whose name is above every name.

His name is Jesus. He saves. That is what the name means. "You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins" (Matthew 1:21).

He is the greater Shamgar. He is the greater Joshua. He is the greater Deliverer. And He is here, not in a field in the hill country, but in the Word and in the Spirit, calling you to Himself.

Response

Let us take a few minutes in silence. I want to ask you three questions, and I want you to answer them honestly before God.

First: What is the field God has given you? Name it. Not the field you wish you had. The one you have. Your home. Your job. Your neighborhood. Your church. Your family. Say it to God.

Second: What is the tool in your hand? What has He already given you that you have been discounting? A skill. A story. A relationship. A verse. A presence. A prayer. A goad. Name it.

Third: Where have you been waiting for a sword? Where have you been saying, "If only I had _____, then I would serve God"? What would it look like to offer the goad instead?

If you are a follower of Jesus, I want you to do one thing this week: one hidden act of faithfulness in the field God has given you. Not a post. Not a platform. Not a performance. A hidden act. A visit. A meal. A letter. A prayer. A repair. A kindness. Something that no one will see but God. And when you do it, remember Shamgar. One verse. One goad. One salvation.

If you are not yet a follower of Jesus, the invitation is not "be like Shamgar." It is "come to the One who took the nails." You do not have to clean up your field first. You do not have to bring a better tool. You come as you are, and He does what only He can do. He saves.

A word of care before we pray. If you have experienced violence, abuse, or the trauma of war, this text can be hard. The story of Shamgar is a story of deliverance from an oppressor, not a command to take revenge. The Bible says, "Beloved, never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God" (Romans 12:19). If you are in danger, please tell someone you trust and get help. The church is meant to be a safe place for the wounded, not a place where they are handed a weapon and left alone.

Let us pray.

Closing

One verse.

That is all the Bible gives Shamgar. A name, a father, an enemy, a number, a tool, and a verdict. No birth. No calling. No sermon. No tomb.

But the verdict is enough. "He also saved Israel."

The world counts mentions. God counts deliverance. The world builds monuments. God builds a kingdom. The world remembers the famous. God remembers the faithful.

Shamgar picked up the goad that was in his hand and did the work that was in front of him. And the God who sees in secret saw him, and the God who writes the record wrote him down.

One sentence. One Savior.

The sentence is short. The salvation is full.

Go and work the field He has given you. Use the tool that is in your hand. Refuse the comparison. Trust the God who counts what the record skips. And when you are tempted to

believe that your one verse does not matter, remember the farmer with the goad, and remember the name above every name.

"After him was Shamgar the son of Anath, who killed 600 of the Philistines with an oxgoad, and he also saved Israel" (Judges 3:31).

He also saved Israel.

And Jesus saves the world.

Evidence note for the preacher

The text. Judges 3:31 is the only narrative verse about Shamgar. It is set "after" Ehud, and it is followed by the Deborah cycle in Judges 4–5. The verse does not mention the Spirit of the LORD, a call, or a speech. It gives a name, a patronymic, an enemy, a number, a weapon, and the verdict "he also saved Israel." Deborah's song (Judges 5:6–8) adds the social world: abandoned highways, travelers on byways, villages ceased, and no shield or spear among forty thousand. The Song of Deborah is widely regarded as one of the oldest extended poems in the Hebrew Bible; the reference to "the days of Shamgar" is therefore an early memory, not a late invention. The chronology of the judges is relative, not absolute; the text does not give us a date, and the sermon should not pretend that it does.

The name. "Shamgar" is of uncertain meaning and possibly non-Semitic origin. "Son of Anath" may point to the Canaanite goddess Anath, to the village of Beth-Anath in Naphtali (Joshua 19:38), to a family or clan name, or to a warrior title reflected in Egyptian "Ben-Anath" names from the Ramesside era. The text does not explain, and the sermon should not settle the question beyond the evidence. What the ambiguity does support is the book's pattern of raising up deliverers from the margins.

The enemy and the setting. The Philistines were part of the Sea Peoples; Ramesses III's Medinet Habu reliefs (c. 1177 BC) depict the defeat of the Peleset and their settlement on the coastal plain. Philistine Iron Age levels at Ashdod and Tel Qasile have produced iron-working evidence. First Samuel 13:19–22 describes the Philistine control of smithing and the sharpening of Israelite farm tools, which fits the archaeology and the social world of Judges 5:6–8. The goad is attested in Egyptian tomb art as a long, iron-tipped pole with a point and a chisel blade. The sermon uses these details to establish plausibility, not to prove the number.

The number. "Six hundred" is a summary figure. The text gives no battle narrative, no time frame, and no tactics. It is possible that the number represents a campaign or a series of engagements rather than a single action. The theological weight of the verse rests on "he also saved Israel," not on the arithmetic. Preachers should avoid both rationalizing the number away and turning it into a stunt.

The gospel. The verb "saved" (*yasha*) is the root behind the name Joshua/Yeshua/Jesus (Matthew 1:21). The sermon's typology is modest: Shamgar is a signpost, not a direct prophecy. The greater Deliverer defeats sin and death not by killing but by dying (Isaiah 53:5; John 19:34; Matthew 27:42), is raised on the third day, and is given the name above every name (Philippians 2:9–11). Hebrews 11:32 does not list Shamgar; the omission is a fact about the selective nature of that roll call, not a verdict on his salvation. The sermon should say this plainly and not manufacture a mention.

Confidence. Strong for the Philistine/iron setting and for the social world of Judges 5:6–8. Moderate for the meaning of the name and for the scale of the campaign. The brevity of the text is the point, not a problem to be solved by speculation. Preach the one verse as it stands, and let the God who inspired it have the last word.